

Who got rich with Open Source

Strap yourself in for an in-depth look at some of the rockstars of Open Source who didn't do too bad despite the inherent odds.

Career in Open Source

sets and you will add new credentials to your resume. This will only bolster your chance of having a better job opportunity in the company of your choice.

When applying for a job, you should try to give full details of the Open Source projects that you have been involved in. You must try to describe the project in as much detail as possible, why you became involved, and your contribution.



Your reputation is your certification

As far as the basic programming related knowledge is concerned, it can be obtained from any reputed training institute. NIIT, Aptech and others provide courses in Linux, MySQL, etc. Once you have the basic training, you will be free to apply your ingenuity and creativity at various projects. The best certification in Open Source development that anyone can hope to have is reputation. There have been many instances where highly commendable contributions to Open Source projects have come from individuals who are still in school or college. Age is clearly no bar for excellence in this field. Once you have done some good work, people within the community of Open Source developers will start recognising you, and slowly you are able to build a reputation.

One of the most popular hangouts for Open Source programmers is SourceForge (<http://sourceforge.net/>). Currently this place has more than 300,469 live projects. Google Code (<http://code.google.com>), the initiative from the search giant Google, offers lot of opportunities to developers not only for posting their own projects and participating in those started by others, but also by way of providing different kinds of tools that can be used for software development. Here you can download the source code for the popular mobile OS, Android, and use it to develop all kinds of apps, which can then be offered in the Android market for free or for a fee. Google Summer of Code, an extension of

Google Code, is a global program that offers student developers stipends for writing code for various Open Source projects. The program has been running since 2005. The 2011 Google Summer of Code, organised in India, saw enthusiastic participation of students from many colleges across the country.

Codeplex (<http://www.codeplex.com>), an initiative of Microsoft, has thousands of Open Source projects running at any point of time. You can also start your own project and if you are creating something interesting then other developers will take notice and join the project for fixing bugs and implementing new features. With certain specific skill sets, you can join commercial Open Source projects like Fedora, Mozilla, Apache, Alfresco, Pentaho, etc. Here the chance of being paid for contributions is pretty high. When you become part of project, you usually begin by becoming a tester. That is you try to identify the bugs, even as you get an inkling of the technology behind it. Eventually you can try to come up with solutions for the bugs. You can also contribute by doing a thorough documentation of the project.

In most cases, the projects running on SourceForge, Codeplex, Google Code



and on many other places on the Internet, remain free from copyright or patent related issues and hence it can be used by everyone. So Open Source development should not be seen only from the angle of bagging a job with higher social status, and better pay and perks, it is also about giving something back to the world. Any free software that gets created has the effect of further enriching the world of IT and that in turn leads to new products and services becoming available to everyone at a cheaper price. Open Source has now come of age, with a vibrant community of developers and entrepreneurs supporting

it. So if you have the necessary skills and the mindset then it is about time you became part of the Open Source movement. ■



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